

How to open a file from a terminal emulator

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This article describes how to open a file from a [terminal emulator](#) in Mac , Linux, and Windows.

1. Mac (macOS)

Use `open` command in [Terminal](#). By running

```
open Readme.txt
```

`Readme.txt` opens with an application associated with `Readme.txt`. URL can be specified. For example,

```
open http://google.com
```

opens Google website with your default web browser. A directory can also be specified. For example,

```
open .
```

opens current directory in Finder.

Sometimes you may want to open a file with a program which is different from the associated one, for example, when you want to edit html file with a text editor. By using `-t` option, you can open a file with a default text editor.

```
open -t filename
```

You can also open a file with a specified application by using `-a` option.

You can make a shell script to open a file with your favorite text editor. For example, to open a file with [Brackets](#), make a text file `br` like this,

```
#!/bin/sh
open $1 -a /Applications/Brackets.app
```

make it executable (`chmod +x br`) and put in your path (check it by `echo $PATH`). Then you can use the `br` command as

```
br filename
```

Following help is shown by `open --help`.

```
Usage: open [-e] [-t] [-f] [-W] [-R] [-n] [-g] [-h] [-s <partial SDK name>] [-b <bundle identifier>] [-a <application>] [filenames]
[--args arguments]
```

Help: `Open` opens files from a shell.

By default, opens each file using the default application for that file.

If the file is in the form of a URL, the file will be opened as a URL.

Options:

```
-a      Opens with the specified application.
-b      Opens with the specified application bundle identifier.
-e      Opens with TextEdit.
-t      Opens with default text editor.
-f      Reads input from standard input and opens with TextEdit.
-F --fresh Launches the app fresh, that is, without restoring windows. Saved persistent state is lost, excluding Untitled documents.
-R, --reveal Selects in the Finder instead of opening.
-W, --wait-apps Blocks until the used applications are closed
```

(even if they were already running).

`--args` All remaining arguments are passed in `argv` to the application's `main()` function instead of opened.

`-n, --new` Open a new instance of the application even if one is already running.

`-j, --hide` Launches the app hidden.

`-g, --background` Does not bring the application to the foreground.

`-h, --header` Searches header file locations for headers matching the given filenames, and opens them.

`-s` For `-h`, the SDK to use; if supplied, only SDKs whose names contain the argument value are searched.

Otherwise the highest versioned SDK in each platform is used.

With `cdto` you can add a toolbar in the Finder to open the current directory in the Terminal.

2. Linux

`xdg-open` can be used to open a file with default applications. `xdg-open` is a part of [xdg-utils](#).

- [xdg-open\(1\) - Linux man page](#)

This command is a little bit too long to type, and therefore you may want to create alias such as

```
alias open=xdg-open
```

in `.bashrc`. In Gnome, `gnome-open` is also available.

- [gnome-open](#) - manual page at Ubuntu xenial

3. Windows

`start` command can be executed from [command prompt](#), and `Invoke-Item` command is used for [PowerShell](#). See following documents by Microsoft for detail.

- [start](#)

- [Invoke-Item](#)